HALAL MEAT

The halal row started after the festival of Ugadi on April 2, when some right-wing groups in Karnataka, including the Hindu Janajagruti Samiti, launched a campaign against the purchase of halal meat, traditionally consumed by Muslims. The BJP's national general secretary C.T. Ravi even compared halal meat to an economic jihad. The protests took a violent turn in Bhadravati in the state's Shivamogga district, where five men were arrested for assaulting a man in a meat shop and another at a restaurant. The next day, Chief Minister Basavaraj Bommai said the state will investigate the halal meat issue as serious objections were raised about it. In November 2021, a similar campaign against halal meat was mounted on social media in Kerala.

LOUDSPEAKERS IN MOSQUES

Over the past year, several right-wing organisations, including the Bajrang Dal, have demanded that the 'azaan' not be offered using loudspeakers. They even threatened to retaliate by playing 'bhajans' on loudspeakers near mosques. On April 2, Maharashtra Navnirman Sena (MNS) chief Raj Thackeray urged the Maharashtra government to remove loudspeakers from mosques and threatened to play the 'Hanuman Chalisa' loudly if his demands were not met. On April 18, the Nashik police commissioner issued an order directing all religious places to seek permission before using loudspeakers by May 3. The police also prohibited the recitation of 'Hanuman Chalisa' within a 150-metre radius of a mosque.

The Supreme Court had in July 2005 banned the use of loudspeakers and music systems between 10 pm and 6 am in public places, except in cases of public emergencies. In August 2016, the Bombay High Court ruled that the use of loudspeaker was not a fundamental right. On May 15, 2020, the Allahabad High Court held that azaan could be recited only by a human voice, without using any amplifying device. In November 2021, the Karnataka High Court asked the state government to explain the provisions of the law under which loudspeakers and public address systems had been allowed in mosques, and what action is being taken to restrict their use.

RAMNAVAMI PROCESSIONS

Several states witnessed Hindu-Muslim clashes during Ramnavami in April. In Khargone, Madhya Pradesh, Muslim locals allegedly pelted stones at a Ramnavami rally, sparking a riot in which houses and shops were set ablaze and over two dozen people were injured. Muslims claim that the people in the procession were playing provocative songs. Similar, if smaller, clashes occurred in Gujarat, Goa, Jharkhand, Karnataka and West Bengal. In Goa and Gujarat, two mosques were set afire for allegedly sheltering stone-pelters. In Delhi's Jawaharlal Nehru University, ABVP students clashed with Left-leaning students over the serving and eating of non-vegetarian food during Navaratri.

HANUMAN JAYANTI PROCESSIONS

Nine people were injured in clashes between Hindus and Muslims on Hanuman Jayanti in Delhi's Jahangirpuri area on April 16. Three processions were taken out and it was the third one that saw trouble since no permission had been granted for it. Those who organised it allegedly took a route next to a mosque located close to a temple. The loud religious chants clashed with the azaan, leading to violence between the two groups. An FIR was registered against the organisers of the procession and nearly 25 people were arrested.